

THE VOTER'S DILEMMA AND SARVODAYA APPROACH



BY
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Tanjore :: India.

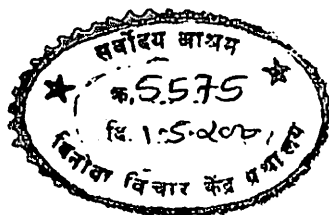
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Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, Tanjore, India.

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PUBLISHERS' NOTE

IT is mistakenly said that Sarvodaya has no politics. Sarvodaya has indeed its politics. But it is not party politics or power politics ever seeking to capture the power of the state machinery. But the politics of Sarvodaya is rooted in serving and enlightening the people for awakening the moral force or *Lok-Niti* to regulate, control and purify the power rested in the state.

Sarvodaya aims at a Stateless Society and a social order free from exploitation of any kind. But as a first step, it has to make democracy effective, basic, direct and responsible for realisation of the Sarvodaya political ideal of a Stateless Society. It is for this that Sri Jayaprakash Narayan presented his thesis of "*Reconstruction of Indian Polity*" two years ago. He has now reduced his thesis to a workable basis of democratic decentralisation in the context of the present elections through a system of *Voters' Councils*.

As there is not sufficient time now to propagate the idea and organise Voters' Councils on the eve of the present elections Sri Appasaheb Patwardhan has posed a serious question as to what a conscientious voter should do now. Should he vote or keep away in the coming elections ?

To this Shri Shankarrao Deo has answered at length. It is a thorough discussion of the socio-economic-political philosophy of *Lok-Niti*. Sri Deo has traced from Gandhiji's advice to the Congress in his "Last Will and Testament" of 29th January 1948 upto the recent resolution of the Akhila Bharath Sarva Seva

Sangh. He has indicated the clear duty of the voter in the present elections for the realisation of Sarvodaya order of Society.

Sri Appasaheb's question and Shri Deo's reply appeared in "Bhoodan" of December 9, 1961 and were reproduced in "Sarvodaya" of January and February 1962. This brochure, which is a reprint of the same is presented before the public to stimulate serious thinking on the socio-political philosophy of Sarvodaya not merely for its relevance to the present elections but for its permanent value.

Tanjore,
January, 62. }

Sarvodaya Prachuralaya.



Please read : "SWARAJ FOR THE PEOPLE" By
Jayaprakash Narayan — Rupee one
available at A. B. S. S. Prakashan, Rajghat, Kashi &
Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, Tanjore.

THE VOTER'S DILEMMA

Appasaheb Patwardhan

[T is well-known that the current system of elections is full of abuses and leads to many evils. A candidate at the elections has to assume the very improper role of begging for votes. He has literally to spend his money like water by way of election expenses. The elections are decided by a majority of votes; victory breeds insolence in the majority, and hatred in the minority, and accentuates the struggle for power. This leads to conflict, violence and many other evils.

As a remedy for all this the Sarva Seva Sangh has initiated the programme of *Lokniti*; but it appears to be incomplete. In the present circumstances it is an impossible task to organize voters' councils, and through their agency to secure uncontested (unanimous) elections. This idea needs to be pursued further, but it cannot be a programme of practical action in the coming elections.

Whom to Vote

Thus the programme of *Lokniti* provides no answer to the questions which confront the average voter: should he cast his vote or not in the coming elections? And if he has to vote, for whom should he vote?

Not to cast one's vote at all appears to be improper. Every voter is in the position of a judge. If a judge refuses to adjudicate between a plaintiff and a defendant he will merely establish his incompetency. He will be acting contrary to his office. He will be guilty of a breach of trust.

In a similar way if a voter refuses to cast his vote he will be failing to discharge his duty and responsibility. As a rule, it is his duty to make a selection among the candidates, and vote for the candidate of his choice.

No Secret Ballot

And in my view a voter should cast his vote openly and not by secret ballot. Under *swaraj* it is the right and duty of every individual to profess his views openly. To vote by secret ballot is to give way to fear.

In selecting a candidate, his views, programme, and capacity for leadership would have to be considered, but more than this importance will have to be attached to the party to which he belongs and its programme. A party is formed on the basis of ideology, programme and leadership. In a party system, competition for power is a great drawback. Yet it is of supreme importance that the voter votes for a candidate and a party whose ideology he accepts. He cannot vote for a good candidate who belongs to a wrong party. He cannot vote for a party which is communal or believes in violence. A voter must, therefore, discriminate between different parties, and exercise his choice between them.

Love for All Parties

"All parties are the same to a Sarvodayite" is an idea that should not be stretched to the limit that we should be indifferent as to which party assumes power. We should have equal love and respect for all parties, should seek the concurrence and co-operation of all, and should not try to exercise the coercive power of the majority on the minority instead of trying to obtain their concurrence.

If we want to keep ourselves aloof from the struggle for power then we must not only not vote for anybody but also persuade others to act in a similar manner.

This is the logical conclusion of keeping ourselves aloof from the struggle for power. But if we have to cast our vote, it will have to be for some party, and in that case, it follows logically that we will have to ask others also to vote in a similar way. To exercise one's vote, and yet not to propagate that view is to take a position which is neither here nor there.

Even amongst the followers of Sarvodaya there could be different views on matters of current interest. For example, some may desire a separate State for the Vidarbha region, while others may desire a single State for all the Marathi speaking people. They would, of course, not resort to violent or unconstitutional methods for achieving their objectives. And yet within the limits of good citizenship they can hold different opinions. In this situation, each would propagate his point of view. And in the process they may provide a practical example of how election centres are conducted in a gentlemanly manner.

Such mutually conflicting ideas arise in my mind, and I am not able to resolve them. I, therefore, desire the guidance of co-workers.

The Forum of Lok-Sabha

There is one more question. Shri Jayaprakash Narayan has placed before the country his scheme of democratic decentralization. This scheme has to be introduced in the Lok-Sabha as a resolution. Who will do so? It is not that the Lok-Sabha will assent to it in a day. It will have

to be introduced and discussed repeatedly. Opinion in the Lok-Sabha will have to be gradually built up. If someone desires to enter the Lok-Sabha just for propagating this scheme—and if there is no other objection to his candidature—will not Jayaprakashji be required to support him? Will it be considered improper to utilise the forum of the Lok-Sabha to propagate one's scheme? It is not an universal rule that elections are fought only for securing political power. Some persons may like to keep themselves aloof from power-politics and yet desire to enter the Legislatures for propagation of their views. Why should one not vote for such propagandists of the Sarvodaya view-point?

My Scheme

I have also my own scheme of ending exploitation. It consists of the following essential points (i) land should belong to all (ii) interest, dividend, and rent, in all forms should cease (iii) currency should automatically depreciate with the passage of time. This scheme cannot be operated unless it is approved and sanctioned by the Lok-Sabha. I do not desire that the Lok-Sabha should approve of it without previous education of public opinion and try to enforce it solely on the strength of State-power. Yet propaganda for the scheme in the Lok-Sabha is an important element in public education; why should we not utilize it? Why should we not let others do so?



VOTER'S DILEMMA

AND SARVODAYA APPROACH

Sankarrao Deo

THE Sarva Seva Sangh desires to create a society based on non-exploitation and freedom from State power. The Sarva Seva Sangh believes that this new society can only be brought into existence by a new Man. So long as an individual does not effect a basic change in himself in accordance with the values of the new society he wants to establish, he cannot be a forerunner in the establishment of such a society. All the revolutions which have occurred up-to-date, particularly those in modern times, have, in the last analysis, proved themselves to be harmful to mankind, though they may have yielded some apparently good results. This has happened, because all these revolutions were based on the idea that a new Man, free and happy, can be created through the imposition of an ideal pattern of society by the coercive power of the State. But a true and lasting change in the human mind cannot be brought about by coercion. The net result has been that almost all the revolutions have ended in strengthening the coercive power of the State and vesting it in the hands of an individual or a class.

Regulate Political Power Through Moral Force

In my opinion there is also another reason for these conflicting thoughts on these subjects which arise in the minds of even

experienced *Lok-sevaks*. We have been very powerfully influenced by Gandhiji's ideas and the efforts he made in his life time to work them out, on the use of State Power in effecting socio-economic changes and the role of political parties in the utilization of State Power. But there has been a significant change in the situation since Gandhiji's times. Gandhiji considered it an essential element in his allegiance to truth that changed circumstances should have their appropriate responses. Gandhiji used to call himself a *philosophical anarchist*.

There is sufficient justification to attribute to Gandhiji the view that he considered it a sin to utilize the State power for effecting social changes, because the State power is at the root of all difficulties and problems with which the world is faced today. Gandhiji believed in a Stateless society. True, as was his wont, he used to say that a Stateless society was like the non-dimensional point of Euclid, an ideal which could never be fully realized in practice, yet all his life he devoted himself to the realization of that ideal. His methodology in this respect was to regulate and control political power through moral force and thus progressively purify political power so that the present society which was largely based on the State power could gradually progress towards freedom from state power.

The basis of this moral force, in his own words, was 'selfless service rendered without attachment and the help of the State power.' This was the main idea which Gandhiji embodied in his 'Last Will and Testament' wherein he advised the Congress to transform itself into a Lok-sevak Sangh. This Will and Testament begins as follows: India

has still to attain social, moral and economic independence in terms of its seven hundred thousand villages as distinguished from its cities and towns. The struggle for the ascendancy of civil over military power is bound to take place in India's progress towards its democratic goal. It must be kept out of unhealthy competition with political parties and communal bodies. For these and other similar reasons the A. I. C. C. resolves to disband the existing Congress Organization and flower into a Lok Sevak Sangh."

Gandhiji's idea was that these *Lok-sevaks* would be educators and servants of the people and through this service, acquire such moral force as would enable them to regulate and control political power. With this object he had prescribed two duties for the would-be *Lok-sevaks*.

(1) He shall see that those whose names are missing on the statutory voters' roll are duly entered therein.

(2) He shall encourage those who have not yet acquired the legal qualification to acquire it for getting the right of franchise.

The Sarva Seva Sangh of today can be said to be an improved edition of the Lok Sevak Sangh of Gandhiji's conception. This is so because the Lok Sevak Sangh of Gandhiji's conception was to have affiliated with it., the Charkha Sangh, the Gramodyoga Sangh, the Talimi Sangh, the Go-seva Sangh and other All-India service institutions. The Sarva Seva Sangh has been evolved in the same manner. That is why the Sarva Seva Sangh has rightly adopted as

its objective, 'the establishment of a society, based on the principles of truth and non-violence and free from all forms of exploitation.' But in the last decade or so, there has been significant change in the situation in the country and there has been a continuous revolution in the method and ideas about achieving this objective. In addition to this, it has become necessary not only in India but the whole world, to reconsider the proposition that the existence of political parties is absolutely essential for the effective functioning of democracy.

Experience of the working of democracy indicates that for the achievement of a stateless society, it is not just enough to control and regulate political power through moral force, and thus progressively purify political power, because there is a limit to this process. Besides, in such a process there remains a contradiction between ends and means which becomes apparent, both in the theoretical formulation and practical working of such a process. It must be admitted that political parties have played a determinate part in the evolution and stabilization of democracy. But the situation today is "that the force itself is eating up the field." These political parties are themselves proving to be burial grounds of true democracy. Therefore, if true democracy which Gandhiji styled as moral democracy is to be established, it can only be done on the exclusive basis of moral force. This was the guiding thought in the following resolution of the Sarva Seva Sangh passed in 1954.

The Objective of the Sarva Seva Sangh

"As the objective of the Sarva Seva Sangh is the establishment of a non-exploitative and stateless society and since the Sangh feels that this objective can only be

achieved through the development of peoples' strength through constructive work and Satyagraha and not through State-power, therefore,

(a) no member of the Sangh shall stand as a candidate for election to Lok-Sabha, the Assemblies, and Councils, District Boards, Municipalities and similar government and semi-government offices, nor would they accept any post which is ordinarily filled through election.

(b) The political parties in the country desire to achieve their objective through the power of the State. The Sarva Seva Sangh desires to take some positive steps for achieving its objective of a stateless society. Therefore, no member of the Sarva Seva Sangh will continue to be even an ordinary member of any political party. This policy has been reaffirmed in the last Sarvodaya Sammelan in the following words :

“The Sarva Seva Sangh believes that a non-violent society can be brought about only through the initiative and the organized and self-reliant strength of the people and not through the administration and political power.

Therefore, the Sarva Seva Sangh reaffirms its policy that it will not directly or indirectly take part in any politics which is directed towards the acquisition of State power.’

Personal Attributes

Even Appasaheb has to accept that while a candidate's personal attributes are important consideration in determining his choice, the party to which he belongs has to be given superior consideration. He further states that “a party is based on ideology, programme and leadership.” But in

my view the chief prop of a political party is its accepted principle that all social changes can only be brought about through the agency of State power, ideology and programme of the party being instruments for the acquisition of State power, assume a secondary importance. Thus acquisition of power by hook or by crook becomes the main pre-occupation of a political party. The characteristic of a political party is that its members believe in reforming society without introducing that reform first in their own lives. Thus, since, on the one hand, it relies exclusively on political power for effecting social changes, it becomes the cause of political demoralization, on the other, since its members try to reform society before reforming themselves, it also becomes the cause of social demoralization. Therefore, if peace and happiness are to be achieved people must search for a method of realizing them without the mediation of a political party. This is the reason why Sarva Seva Sangh has been trying for decentralized democracy instead of the present much boasted centralized democracy based on the party system.

Lok-Niti

Appasaheb has rightly pointed out that the Sarva Seva Sangh's programme of *Lokniti* has emerged out of these efforts. Its chief basis is the principle that the people should order their own affairs through their organized and their self-reliant initiative rather than entrusting them to the elected representatives to whom they delegate for this purpose their rights and suzerainty. The practical way of operating this idea is that the people themselves should try to achieve through the medium of voters' councils. The three main functions of drawing up a programme, setting up candidates and exercising control over them are discharged by political parties today.

The people merely content themselves by selecting a candidate belonging to a particular political party. The result is that the people lose their initiative and remain the final repositories of political power only in name. Thus a peoples' government run by the people themselves can never be established through such a democracy functioning through political parties.

If the people thus take into their own hands, through their voters' councils, all the functions of a political party, the State and the people will then become almost the same and mutually convertible institutions, and the evil of political power which has crept into today's politics, will gradually disappear.

Voters' Councils

Appasaheb feels that the programme of voters' councils is not a political proposition today. It could be a subject for further thought, but cannot be a programme of practical action in the forthcoming elections. But if we agree that this programme is right and desirable, it will have to be acted upon some time. If this programme of voters' councils could be operated even in a small measure in different places in the country it will gradually spread like oil on the surface of water and in course of time become extensive. And only in this way can a people's government be born in the near future. We who rely on the people should not become distressed with the thought that such a programme will take a long time to materialize. We have no better alternative to this. The argument that such a programme will take a long time to get started and to develop should not appeal to us.

But the question still remains if the Sarva Seva Sangh has any directions to give to people, who have to vote for

candidates under the existing system of elections in the context of the present political parties, in the event of the voters' councils not being established on a sufficiently extensive scale. If the Sarva Seva Sangh had no programme for such people to enable them to reach their goal, it would have become indistinguishable from any other organization. The coming elections are not the first since the establishment of the Sarva Seva Sangh. Two elections have taken place already. And during these the Sarva Seva Sangh provided clear guidance for the voters. The present programme of voters' councils is merely an evolved form of the policy of the Sangh during last two elections. This is not to say that the policy followed during the last two elections was wrong or incorrect. It was quite appropriate to the period. Even today according to the Sarva Seva Sangh, that policy is the most correct policy for all those who find themselves in the same position as during the last election. Even the recent resolution of the Sarva Seva Sangh clearly states that those who want to vote should do so on the basis of their independent judgment. Naturally, (it is expected that) they will not cast their vote under the influence of a narrow outlook based on violence, caste, linguistic and other similar considerations. The purity of voting is preserved when a voter refuses to cast his vote under pressure, or other influences in favour of a candidate, who he feels, does not represent his own views on political, social, economic and other matters. If the voter finds that such a candidate is not available then his clear duty is not to cast his vote at all.

Voter's Duty

Appasaheb writes, "it does not appear appropriate to refuse to cast one's vote. Every voter is in the position of a judge. If a judge refuses to decide between a plaintiff and a defendant then he will be merely demonstrating his

incompetency. That will be dishonest of him. As a rule, it is his duty to select a candidate and vote for him."

But it is not correct to equate a voter with a judge. The duty of a voter is not to decide where justice lies between two contending parties. In a sense he is a master and he has to decide which agent out of two or three he should use for doing his work. May be, he comes to the conclusion that out of the candidates who are offering their services none is good or competent enough to act as his servant or agent. In these circumstances, he may choose not to vote at all, and face the result of that action rather than be held responsible for putting in an incompetent agent. You know that Acharya Kripalani believes in utilizing the power of the State, and the party system. But today he is an independent because he feels that there is no political party today through which he can utilize political power for public good. It is possible that the voter may come to the conclusion that no political party is capable of representing him, and he chooses not to vote. Exercise of a vote is a right. This means that it is up to a voter to exercise this right or not. What is compulsory is not a right. It becomes a duty. The Sarva Seva Sangh has stated as follows in its resolution on the 1956 elections: "Every person, to whatsoever political parties he may belong, knows that as it is the bounden duty of a citizen to vote in an election, under certain circumstances it is also his bounden duty not to cast his vote at all. Therefore, if one's party sets up a wrong candidate, it becomes the duty of even party members not to vote for such a party candidate."

Sangh' Advice to Voters

I will now deal with the main question raised by Appasaheb, *viz*, what advice the Sarva Seva Sangh has to give to a voter

who desires to vote in the elections. It would be desirable in this connection to examine the variations in policy undergone by the Sarva Seva Sangh in 1951, 1956 and 1961. In 1951, the S. S. S. believed in the utilization of State power for achieving its ends. The 1951 resolution stated "that the Sarva Seva Sangh did not consider that the election manifestoes of the various political parties are adequate for the establishment of a Sarvodaya society, nor did it feel confident that they (i.e., the different political parties) would be in a position, on being placed in power, to execute their programmes fully and effectively. Therefore, the S. S. S. is not in a position to back any of the political parties."

It, however, envisaged a situation when the constructive workers themselves would be called to power. It went on to state as follows :—

"The question about the exercise of political power by constructive workers can only arise, when people feel likewise and decide to place none else but the constructive workers in power, but this is yet a far cry."

It was also felt then that a political party opposed to the principles of Sarvodaya would make its realization difficult, and was likely to create obstruction in the path of constructive workers. Therefore, it recognized that constructive workers could not be indifferent as to which political party assumed power, and advised them and the voters as follows :—

"..... They (the constructive workers) should take an intelligent interest in the politics and administration of the country and educate the voters so that they realize the significance of the sacredness and power of the right to vote and learn to cast it thoughtfully and intelligently with a view to secure the purity of public life and the welfare of the people.

“The S.S.S. advises the voters, that they should not cast their votes in favour of a candidate, who does not possess, in their opinion, the necessary standard of purity in social and political life, even if he has been nominated by the same political party to which they belong. The voters should further remember that they should never cast their votes for a candidate, who is communal minded, or who believes in the use of violent methods for the achievement of his objectives, because such an attitude is against the principles of Sarvodaya.”

In 1956, there was a change in the policy of the S. S. S. It was felt that Socio-economic changes could be better achieved through educating the people in that behalf rather than through the utilization of State power. The resolution of 1956 clearly enunciated for the first time that ‘a non-violent society could never be established through the agency of State-power’. It, therefore, stated as follows.

‘The objective of the S. S. S. is the establishment of a non-violent society. It is an article of faith with the S.S.S. that such a society cannot be established through the agency of State-power. It is an accepted principle that the ultimate sanction in a democracy rests on the will of the people. Therefore, the S. S. S. will not take part, directly or indirectly in any politics, directed towards the achievement of State-power. The S. S. S. looks with an attitude of neutrality towards the party in power in the country as well as the other parties who desire to wield such power. Today democracy is based on the party system. The S. S. S. feels that it is necessary to take an attitude transcending all political parties if democracy is to be based on the people as distinguished from political parties. Therefore, it cannot have any interest in the victory of one party as against another,

because the process of conversion transcends all concepts of victory and defeat.....

...Therefore, the S. S. S. will neither participate in the elections nor tender any advice to individuals concerning the same. But lest some of the sentences in the above resolution would appear to be so widely worded as to draw the inference that the S. S. S. was literally indifferent to the professions and practice of the political party which served power in the State, the following was added :

‘In the present circumstances some persons professing the Sarvodaya view-point would like to cast their votes. Obviously, they would not like to cast their votes for candidates professing communalism or violence...’

This clearly qualified the attitude of neutrality towards political parties. This attitude was not to apply to communal parties or those believing in violence. It was to emphasize this aspect that I wrote as follows to shri. Kelappan during the state-wide agitation in Kerala against the Communist Government there demanding interim elections.

“I feel that the crucial point which should influence us, I mean those who believe in the principles of Sarvodaya and the theory of conversion, is how the communist party is using the power which they have obtained through democratic methods. Not only in political life alone, but in general life also, the difference between theory and practice, immediate and the long-term, must be considered in their proper perspective by those who believe in the theory of conversion.”

That is, the question whether a particular political party is communal or violent has to be decided with reference to their professions and practices.

The 1956 resolution thus gave a certain direction to the voters who desired to cast their votes while at the same time changed the emphasis for achieving the Sarvodaya objective from the capture of political power to the education of the people.

In 1961, a further advance was made in the direction of the people's utilization of State-power. The S. S. S. directed that the people should form voters' councils, and cast their vote for candidates put in by these voters' councils and not for candidates put in the field by parties. If political power was to be used at all, it was better that the people use it directly and not through the agency of a party. The 1961 resolution thus gave body and form to that part of the 1956 resolution which had declared that democracy would have to transcend the party system. It indicated to the people a method of doing so. They were to ignore candidates set up by political parties, and instead set up their own candidates through the medium of the voters' councils.

Appasaheb has raised the further question that even amongst the followers of Sarvodaya, various people may hold different views on current questions. If we take the question of a separate State for Vidarbha though the followers of Sarvodaya holding differing view-point, on this issue would not resort to violent or unconstitutional methods in support of their views, they may, as Appasaheb feels, be required to get these issues resolved by resorting to political methods. In such a case, each person will campaign for his point of view. Considering the evolution of Sarvodaya thought, this type of argument appears old and far-fetched today, the followers of Sarvodaya will not only not resort to violent or unconstitutional methods for the solution of their problems, but also they would not think of finding a

solution for them through the agency of the state-power. They would like to get a solution for them, through public education, and would try to persuade other people also follow the same cause.

Heavy Price

Finally, Appasaheb feels that if the Sarvodaya view-point is to be accepted by the nation, the Lok-Sabha is an appropriate forum for propagating it, and it should be used accordingly. On a superficial view, this idea appears plausible, and attractive. But if we think a bit more deeply we shall realize what a high price will have to be paid for such conduct. The Lok-Sabha of today, unlike the Central Assembly of the pre-independence period is not merely an instrument of national propaganda, it is also a legislative organ. In order to enable us to carry on propaganda through its agency for the achievement of our larger objectives, we must either ourselves become its members or actively help others to become so. In either case we subject ourselves to and morally accept its authority as an instrument through which the power of the State is exercised, and this is a very heavy price we will have to pay. This will also land us in another difficulty. Thereby we shall be strengthening the present system of democracy, which is operating through political parties. Therefore, people, who believe in moral means for the achievement of their objectives, should keep themselves away from the attraction of utilizing the agency of the Lok-Sabha for propagating their ideas.

There is, no doubt, that if any reference is to be accepted by the people, and is to be incorporated in the Constitution of the country, it will have to obtain the seal of approval of the Lok-Sabha. Therefore, such candidates, as desire to enter the Lok-Sabha for propagating our viewpoint,

will have our good wishes. This is inevitable. But we will not be their propagandists. It is on thing to give our blessings to a person who is out to do a particular piece of good work, and help him to achieve it, and quite another thing for the sake of that one thing, to give him direct or indirect support for everything else that he does.

Before any idea is accepted by the Lok-Sabha, it is necessary that education of the people on mass scale should precede it. This is the corner stone of the policy of *Lokniti*. We should educate the people on the different questions which face them, try to rouse their initiative, and involve them fully in an effort to solve their problems through their own initiative.



BHOODAN LITERATURE

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